continent was articulated by him in July 2018 in an address to the Ugandan Parliament. Its essence was that India would respond to Africa's priorities, demands and needs rather than unilaterally propose an agenda. Since 2014, there have been 34 outgoing visits by the Indian president, vice president and PM to Africa, and more than a hundred incoming ones at the same level. The IAFS of 2015 laid out particularly ambitious targets for cooperation.

A decade later, despite the interruption by Covid, much of that was agreed upon has been delivered in terms of projects, capabilities, training and exchanges. Apart from practical collaboration, the solidarity with Africa is best expressed by how strongly India has pushed for its membership of the G20.

To date, India has done about 200 projects in Africa, with 65 more under execution and 81 in the works. Many of these projects were the first of their kind in Africa. Some are truly iconic in nature such as the Tema–Mpakadan Railway and Presidential Palace in Ghana, National Assembly building in Gambia, the Rivatex textile factory in Kenya, the Metro Express project in Mauritius and the Mahatma Gandhi International Convention Centre in Niger.

The narrative in other related domains has also been encouraging. More than 40,000 scholarships have been extended since the last IAFS meeting. A pan-Africa e-network launched a decade ago is supplemented by the e-VidyaBharti and e-ArogyaBharti initiatives on distant education and health respectively. We are today Africa's fourth-largest trade partner and fifth-largest investor. India's contribution of vaccines, medicines and equipment was particularly crucial during the Covid pandemic. The discussion is increasingly now on digital delivery, green growth and affordable health as the three themes of future development collaboration.

THE BRIDGES NOT TOO FAR

While Africa has been the main focus of lines of credit and grant assistance, India's growing footprint in Latin America is also worth noting. From being perceived as a faraway destination, that continent is gaining salience as a supplier of energy, natural resources and food. Its expanding middle class are natural customers for Indian products in pharmaceuticals and vehicles. The Indian IT industry is also firmly entrenched in the Latin American